(b) What will return?

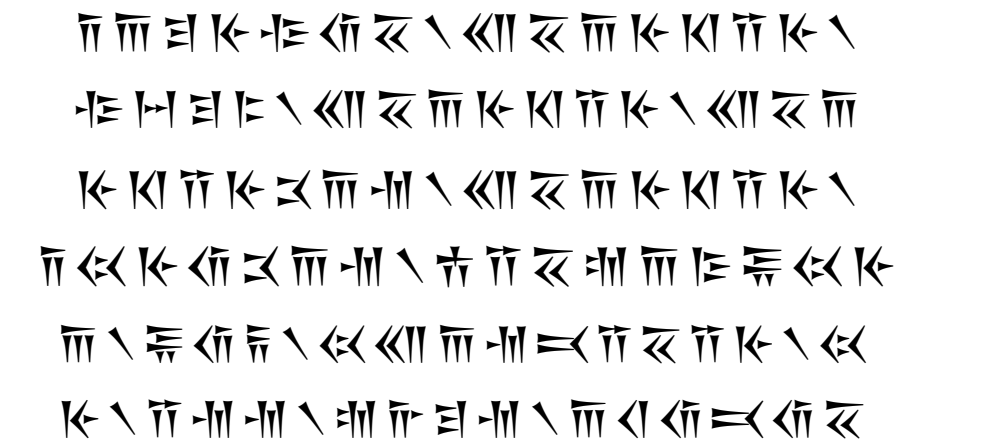
Assignment 4: (8 marks)
Explain your solution.

– Vlad A. Neacşu (inspired by a problem created by Adina Dragomirescu)

Problem 5: Old Persian (20 marks)

Old Persian was spoken from 600-300 BCE in Achaemenid Persia. It was written in cuneiform[10]. Since the medieval times travelers had noticed the Old Persian inscriptions in cuneiform carved in the palaces and ruins of Persepolis, a city in Iran. However, the script remained undeciphered till 18th century. In 1802, Georg Friedrich Grotefend, a German philologist, managed to (almost correctly) decipher most of the script starting from two simple inscriptions, known as the Niebuhr inscriptions 1 and 2.[11]

Niebuhr inscription 1:



Niebuhr Inscription 2:



Based on the repetition patterns in the two inscriptions and context in which they occur, Grotefend correctly guessed that the translation of the first inscription should be:

[10] Cuneiform was a writing system produced using wedge-shaped marks in clay tablets, inherited from the Sumerian Empire.

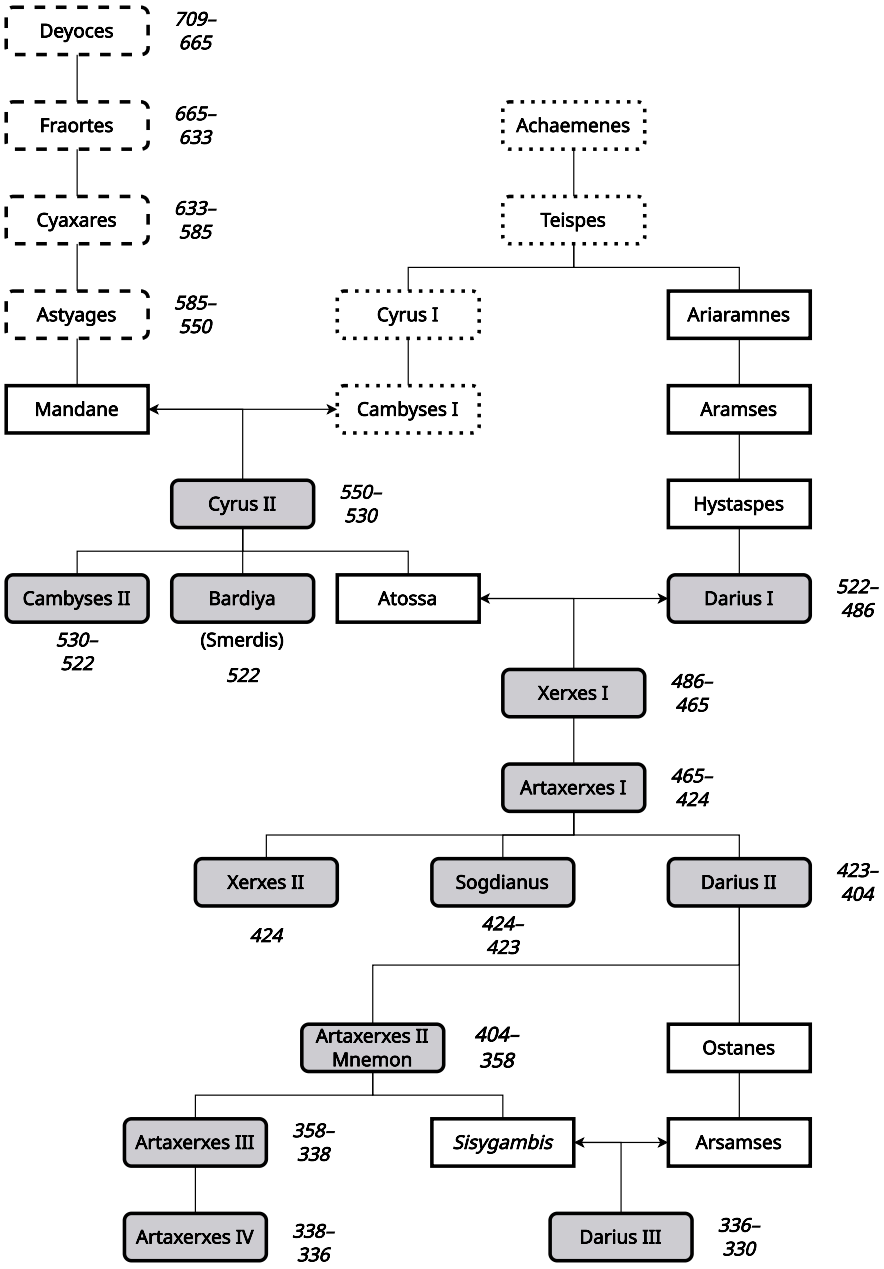
[11] Slightly simplified for this problem.

Translation 1: *A, the Great King, King of Kings, King of countries, son of B, an Achaemenian, who built this Palace.*

Note: *Achaemenian* refers to a descendant of Achaemenes.

Grotefend deciphered the above words without deciphering the letters. He could see that the second inscription also mentions two names, let's say, C and D (in that order).

At first, Grotefend was unable to decipher the names - A, B, C and D. However, the family tree of the Achaemenid dynasty gave him enough clues to pin down the names. The tree is shown below. The names follow the modern English spellings that closely reproduce the Greek pronunciations of the Old Persian words. The Achaemenid kings (descendants of Achaemenes who also reigned) are shown in shaded boxes. The reigning periods of all the kings have been shown as well.



Assignment 1: (5 marks)

Translate Niebuhr inscription 2 into English (you can use C and D for the names).

Assignment 2: (7 marks)

Identify A, B, C, and D. Explain how you arrived at your answer.

Assignment 3: (5 marks)

Give the Old Persian cuneiforms for the following English words:

(a) King

(b) Son

(c) Achaemenian

Assignment 4: (3 marks)

What do the following cuneiform symbols stand for:

(a) 

(b) 

(c) 

– Monojit Choudhury

This is the end.